The hero’s journey

Hi everyone, and welcome to this fourteenth episode of the Cottongue Podcast!

[00:00:17] To begin this new podcast, I’d particularly like to welcome new listeners. I see many new people have started listening, and that makes me very happy.

[00:00:37] People listening for the first time often ask why I don’t teach grammar. It’s true that in other podcasts for learning French, grammar is often central. For example, podcasts teach different rules, explain mistakes to avoid or how to conjugate first-group verbs.

[00:01:12] Since all these podcasts already exist, I don’t want to do the same thing. Besides, if you listened to my first podcast, you know I don’t consider grammar the most important thing when learning a language. I think enjoying yourself matters most. Because if we enjoy learning a language, we’ll want to work regularly, and regular work brings progress.

[00:01:52] So what I offer with this podcast is a new subject every week that I discuss to try to interest you. At least, these are subjects I find interesting, and I hope they make you want to understand the language and use French as much as possible.

[00:02:21] In any case, if you like my podcast, don’t hesitate to leave comments on iTunes, because that helps me enormously.

[00:02:40] Today, I’ve decided to talk about cinema. But I won’t discuss a particular film or director. Instead, I’ll discuss how screenwriters write stories for films. Do you know what Luke Skywalker, Harry Potter and Aladdin have in common? You probably know these three characters, these three heroes, but do you know their similarities, what they share? All three are main heroes of films, or an animated film in Aladdin’s case: he’s the hero of a Disney animation. OK, but that isn’t the most interesting thing. What’s most interesting is that they experienced rather similar adventures. You’re probably thinking, “But Hugo, what are you talking about? Luke Skywalker’s, Harry Potter’s and Aladdin’s adventures are completely different! They have nothing to do with each other!” Perhaps that’s your impression, but looking at their structure, we see they’re actually very similar. That’s precisely what I’ll discuss today. Do you want to know the magic recipe for writing a good film screenplay? Yes? OK, listen, and I’ll give you this magic recipe.

[00:04:55] Sometimes at the cinema, don’t you feel a sense of déjà vu? You know, the feeling of having already experienced a similar situation, already been in this situation. Sometimes we feel we’ve seen it in a dream, for example, but aren’t really sure. Do you know why you feel this at the cinema? Because many films use a similar structure. Their stories resemble other films’ stories. You might think screenwriters are lazy. Instead of writing, inventing a new story, they prefer copying another screenwriter’s story. That’s less tiring and requires less work. You also know that producers, meaning the people financing films, take less risk making a sequel to a very successful film than financing a completely new film people don’t know. For example, everyone loves Spider-Man, so financing Spider-Man 2, 3, 4 or 5 is less risky than creating a film with a new hero the public doesn’t know. Then there’s a risk the public won’t like this new hero. If the hero isn’t popular, naturally the film won’t succeed. To take fewer risks, producers prefer ingredients that already work.

[00:07:21] One ingredient works extremely well for successful films: a very effective structure theorised by an American anthropologist. An anthropologist studies humans, physically but also culturally. Anthropologists bring together all sciences concerning humans to try to obtain an overall view of humanity. This American anthropologist was Joseph Campbell. He was very interested in mythology and myths. Myths are very, very old stories spreading through civilisations, passed from generation to generation, sometimes also called legends. They're so old that often we don't know their author, who first wrote or told the myth, the story.

[00:08:54] Joseph Campbell studied myths in different civilisations worldwide. He studied their stories and tried to find common features. Through his research, he identified a structure shared by myths in all these civilisations. Greek, Roman or Mayan myths all share a certain order, a certain structure for telling the story. Joseph Campbell wrote a book to show, to explain this structure to the general public.

[00:09:54] I imagine you're wondering about this story's structure, the different stages the hero must face. A stage is like a test, something the hero must do to test his courage, his bravery. Generally, these trials are the same in all stories. That's what's so interesting. Since you're curious to know these trials, I'll describe them.

[00:10:42] The first trial isn't really a trial, but rather the initial situation. The hero lives in an ordinary world, but doesn't yet know he's a hero. He thinks he's like everyone else, or even, quite often, worse than others. Before becoming a hero, he's often somewhat marginalised, a "loser", as we say in English. Think of Harry Potter: before joining the school, his life is rather sad. He's an orphan because he lost his parents in a car accident, and lives with his aunt's family, who completely hate him. He has no friends, so his life isn't exactly ideal. It's the same for Luke Skywalker. As a child, he grows up on Tatooine in a rather poor family. Although he has good physical abilities, nobody thinks he'll become a hero then. Aladdin is simply a thief, called a "good-for-nothing" in Disney's animation. A "good-for-nothing" is a person with no value: their value is zero! So before meeting the genie, Aladdin is far from a hero. This is every story's first stage, the basis of different myths: a rather ordinary character in an equally ordinary world.

[00:12:59] Next, the second stage is a call the hero receives, a call to adventure. This call can take different forms: a telephone call, a letter, or someone visiting to propose an adventure.

[00:13:32] Generally, the hero initially refuses. That's stage three, when he refuses the adventure. He has different excuses, but generally simply disagrees. Perhaps he's afraid, perhaps he thinks he isn't the right person for these trials. In any case, his initial reaction is simply saying "no". "No, sorry, but I'm not going on an adventure." For example, Luke Skywalker doesn't initially want to follow Obi-Wan Kenobi. He wants to stay on Tatooine and doesn't want an adventure.

[00:14:33] But finally, in the fourth trial, a mentor convinces the hero. A mentor is a very important person with more experience than us, who gives advice for living better. In Harry Potter, for example, the mentor is Hagrid. In Aladdin, it's the genie. In Star Wars, of course, it's Obi-Wan Kenobi. This mentor talks to the hero and explains that he must accept the adventure, that it's his destiny and there's no alternative to going.

[00:15:40] Now we reach the fifth stage. The hero accepts the adventure, and in doing so enters an extraordinary world, different from his previous one. This is when the adventure truly begins.

[00:16:11] In this new universe, things become complicated for the hero. He has many challenges to meet to prove he's worthy of his destiny: confronting villains, helping people, saving princesses and so on. Lots of trials give him opportunities to prove his courage, prove he isn't ordinary but truly a hero. A very good example comes from Greek mythology. You've probably heard of Hercules, a Greek mythological hero who was half-human, half-god, the son of Zeus and a human woman. To prove he was a hero, Hercules had to perform twelve labours. These labours were trials showing his worth, proving he really was a hero.

[00:17:39] The seventh stage is the final trial. After all the difficulties he's faced, the hero encounters the last trial, generally the hardest. It might be a battle against the main villain, or saving a princess from a dragon. This stage is extremely difficult, and the hero comes very close to death. That's the eighth stage, when he's near death. Watching a film, this is the most stressful moment because we really want the hero to succeed, but the battle is so difficult that he's about to lose.

[00:18:49] Fortunately, in stage nine, the hero succeeds in this last trial. He wins the final battle and proves he truly is a hero.

[00:19:16] After this victory, he can return to his original world. There's always a return to the original world. Another Greek myth illustrates this: Ulysses. You know, the man who had to make a great sea voyage and lost his homeland, Ithaca. For many, many years he travels, travels, facing many trials and challenges. Finally, after all these challenges, he manages to return home, to Ithaca. That's another example illustrating Campbell's theory.

[00:20:12] At the end, the hero has returned to his original world, but things have changed because he's different. He's no longer the same man, or woman, as before leaving. Now he's a hero, with extraordinary abilities, no longer a human like everyone else. It's the same with Harry Potter. Returning home after a year at wizarding school, he's back among humans, with his aunt's family, but he's different. He has magical powers, he's a wizard, no longer the same Harry Potter as before he left for wizarding school.

[00:21:11] This structure therefore forms a circle. There's a starting point, the hero in his ordinary world, then the different stages, then he returns to the beginning. But of course, as I said, he's different.

[00:21:32] Knowing this structure, we can analyse many, many films and find it in all of them. Think of those I mentioned: Star Wars, Harry Potter, Aladdin, but also The Matrix, The Lord of the Rings, Finding Nemo or The Lion King. Disney studios really love using this structure. An American writer and screenwriter called Christopher Vogler published a guide for Hollywood screenwriters inspired by Campbell's structure. This book is very popular and greatly influenced Hollywood screenwriters. That's why we find the formula everywhere, in many different films.

[00:23:52] Why do you think this structure is so effective? Why does the public like these stories so much?

[00:23:03] In my opinion, the first thing is that viewers can identify with the hero. Since the hero is an ordinary person with problems, we can recognise ourselves in him, put ourselves in his shoes. In French, “se mettre dans la peau de quelqu’un”, literally “to put oneself in someone’s skin”, means putting ourselves in their place, imagining we’re that person. When we put ourselves in the hero’s shoes, the film becomes more intense because we feel the events happening to him are happening to us, the viewers.

[00:23:57] Secondly, through this hero, we understand we can overcome our fears. We understand we must sometimes take risks and accept the call to adventure. Being afraid is normal. Everyone’s afraid, even heroes. What makes the difference is accepting risks and deciding to fight our fears. That’s how we can become heroes. But becoming a hero requires great courage and sacrifices. We also like this idea, because personal development, for example, is increasingly popular. We all want to become better versions of ourselves. In this structure, this story, the hero becomes a better version of himself. Again, we like identifying with this kind of character.

[00:25:14] The last thing explaining these stories’ popularity, in my opinion, is their very clear, easy-to-understand structure. Disney’s children’s films use it because children can understand it very easily. Parents too! Since it’s a circle, a story shaped like a circle, with a beginning and an end, we feel we’ve experienced a complete adventure. At the film’s end, no questions remain. Every question has been answered, we know exactly what happened, and we’re satisfied, happy to have seen the film and experienced the adventure.

[00:26:27] Ultimately, all these ingredients guarantee success for producers because they already know viewers like this kind of story. But perhaps using this structure in every film risks making viewers tired of it. “To grow tired of something” means getting fed up, no longer liking it. For example, if you love chocolate cake and eat it every day, after a few weeks perhaps you’ll grow tired of it. You won’t want to eat more because you’ve had too much already. It’s the same with films: seeing these stories again and again, perhaps the public will have had enough. On the other hand, Joseph Campbell proved this structure has existed for thousands of years. If it’s still effective now, perhaps it will always appeal to audiences, and viewers will never grow tired of it.

[00:28:11] That’s the end of this podcast. Next time you go to the cinema, you can try identifying the structure, perhaps recognising Joseph Campbell’s structure. I hope you found this interesting and are still motivated to learn French. Even on holiday, keep doing a little French every day, because you know regularity is the key to learning a language.

[00:28:51] If you want to help me and like this podcast, I invite you to leave a rating on iTunes. Write a short comment and give me stars so my podcast can help even more people. If you like it, go to iTunes and leave a little review.

[00:29:26] Thank you, everyone, for listening. We’ll meet again next week to talk about the French education system, meaning school in France. Rest well, enjoy your holidays if you’re on holiday, and see you soon!